

If you want to know the difference between what you truly love and the manufactured desires in your life, we think the single most effective thing you can do is a no-spend challenge, especially if you want to see results fast.

FedEx spent six years working on creating the first paperless cockpit,⁶ a system that would save them time and money and make many of their other projects easier to complete. They'd had this goal, planned for it, and allocated resources to it for more than six years, but with literally fifty other priorities competing for attention, it inched along. When FedEx decided to focus on this one thing, they got clear on what needed to be done, in what order, and rallied the team behind the plan. They had the system launched and in use in *two weeks*.

On any given day, there are thousands of decisions to make. With every decision competing for our attention, it's nearly impossible to figure out what you love and don't love spending money on. But if you commit for thirty days to having a singular focus on your spending, you could potentially gain years of progress in just a couple weeks.

How to Do a No-Spend Challenge

The goal of a no-spend challenge and a dopamine fast are the same: when you cut out or cut back on actions that give you a dopamine rush, you can retrain your brain to respond to those triggers less impulsively. The one rule of a no-spend challenge is straightforward: don't spend money on anything nonessential. But where there are rules, there are always exceptions. We've done many no-spend challenges ourselves and with our podcast listeners, and here are some of the exceptions and questions that come up every time:

“What if my car runs out of gas?”

First ask yourself, “Am I impulse buying gas?” and “Am I trying to meet a need with this gas that I could meet in another, less expensive or free way?” For the majority of people, the answers to these questions will be “no.” Most of us aren't stress shopping at the pump. If your car runs out of gas, get more gas. Same with any number of necessary household items. The